With remove, we don’t have to worry about splitting edges or adding bridge nodes: since we need to find the key first, there must be a path perfectly matching the key to be deleted, in order to be able to complete the operation; we might, however, have the chance to compact the final part of the deleted path, because turning an existing key node into an intermediate node can change tree structure introducing a pass-through node (see 6.3.1).

Figure 6.20 shows an example of method remove in action on a radix tree.

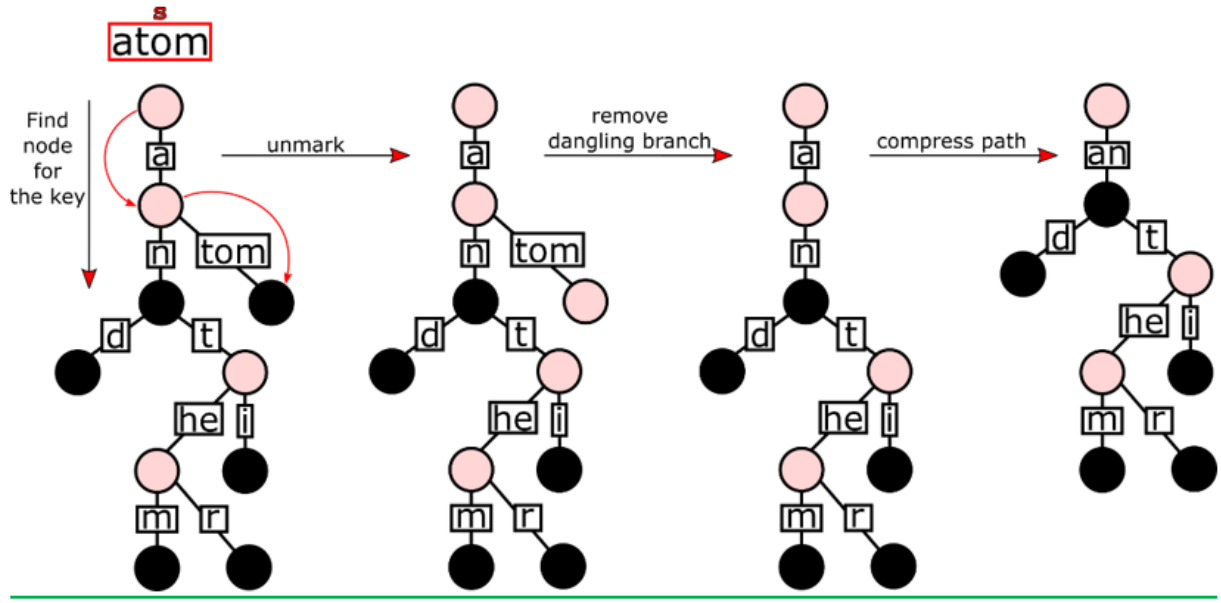


Figure 6.20 Removing the word “atom” from an example radix trie.
(1) Find the node at the end of the path for the key to delete. The path must entirely match the key, clearly.
(2) Unmark the node, making it an intermediate node. If the node is a leaf, it will create a dangling branch.
(3) Remove the dangling branch. If the parent of the node removed had only 2 children, now it became a